

« Indian players tend to be a lot more aggressive »

MAX SENICA

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Former athletes becoming coaches is not an uncommon practice, but current players engaging in coaching is a rare sight; Max Senica is one of those rare individuals.

Senica, a member of the Australian national volleyball team since 2021, also coaches and conducts camps for young talents at the Sharks Volleyball programme in Australia.

The 24-year-old is now a part of the Ahmedabad Defenders outfit in the third season of Prime Volleyball League, courtesy positive feedback from his friend and former Hyderabad Black Hawks middle blocker, Trent O'Dea.

The Defenders has always been in the top rung of the points table, and Senica hopes to maintain it and help it defend its title. The team has made it to the Super 5, after the initial league phase.

Fortuitous encounter

When young, Senica had no intention of taking up volleyball in the first place. But since his family was into football, his ambition was to play any sport.

"I didn't want to attend school but wanted to be an athlete in anything. I had to choose a sport, and football did not start until later in high school. I was not a good swimmer and was

too tall for a gymnast. Volleyball was the last option, so I thought I'd try it," said the Australian.

However, it was not until much later that he realised that he wanted to specialise in the sport and make a living. "I decided to become a professional athlete when I was eight. I started taking volleyball seriously when I was 15-16 and decided that would be my life and job."

Having made his mark in Denmark, Cyprus and Qatar, Senica joined the Defenders camp for the Volleyball Men's Club World Championship 2023 held in Bengaluru and continued his journey with the club for PVL 3.

"When they (Defenders) approached me for the World Champs and PVL, I thought this was an opportunity to showcase my skills. The Worlds wasn't a

tournament where we would play for fun. We were there to win and compete. I feel we certainly showed our ability to play at the international level," said the 6' 8"-tall outside hitter.

Facing global powerhouses Itambe Minas and the eventual winners Sir Sicoma Perugia, the Defenders lost both matches in straight sets. Senica did not brood over the losses and moved on to spend Christmas in Australia, awaiting his Indian expedition.

New coach, new system

When he returned to India for the league in January, the coach he trained under for the Worlds (S. Dakshinamoorthy) was replaced by a Serbian coach, Dragan Mihailovic. This meant that Senica had to adapt to a new style of play.

"We've had a big adjustment by introducing new systems, ways of



"No player is guaranteed a position on the court at any time, which is the best thing that can be for any professional team. You don't want players making it easy at training," says Max Senica.